

Deciding whether the purchase is purposeful:

- Do I need this?
- Do I own a duplicate?
- Where will I put it?
- How will I pay for it?
- Can I really afford it?

‘If you can answer those satisfactorily and you still think your purchase is subjectively okay, and it is not going to cause consequences, then that is your marker,’ Laving says.

4. Time to ride out the urge

On this point, Laving says:

Do something else for five minutes and what will happen usually is the urge will subside, so you are not going to feel such a powerful pull. If that hasn’t happened, what I say to people is, ‘What is it that you think you really need?’ Quite often, overshopping or overspending is trying to meet other needs, to regulate mood, to deal with frustration, boredom or lack of satisfaction in your life. I tell clients that I notice a pattern, where after a trigger they immediately go to the behaviour. So we practise mindful shopping and spending. Of course you need to buy things, but build up a mindful pause; say to yourself, ‘Hang on a minute, what am I doing? I already own a pair of shoes like that. How else can I manage this feeling, and how else can I meet this need in a healthy way?’ It might be writing out a list of alternative healthy activities you can engage in.

Decide on your go-to action. For me, shopping was triggered by boredom and loneliness, so I would leave a shop and visit my baby niece for a play, to enforce how rich my life was minus the materialism. For you, it could be as simple as going for a walk, picking up a book, ringing a friend who you have not contacted in a while, or doing housework. The most mundane action can have a profound effect.